

something cheaper he showed me the WRT120N – this struck me a sweet deal, it's a wireless N router sans frills and is priced at Rs. 2,600 – suitable for someone who wants to connect multiple devices used for browsing mainly and for smaller homes, like mine.

If you are a discerning buyer, please do some reading up on the chipset used in the router as this affects performance. Atheros chipsets, for example, are poorer performers while the better chipsets come from the likes of Broadcom and Intel. However, for most users, this will not matter a great deal and many will not even notice a difference. Placement of your router is also important. As much as possible avoid keeping it amid other articles on a table, a clear line-of-sight is important. Also avoid keeping it near metal objects. Before buying, check if the router is also wall-mountable, useful if you have less desk space. Mounting on a wall also eliminates the problem of line-of-sight. You'll need to check with your notebook which spot offers optimal coverage, but really for surfing, this does not matter.

The next shop had the Linksys WRT160N and Netgear WNR2000. The latter was priced very well at Rs. 4,100 and the WRT160N available for 5,500 bucks. The WNR2000 is something we tested this year and I must say, if you're looking at a real fast performer, or you have a larger home this is very suitable, especially since it's well priced. I also came across DLink's Xtreme 655, priced at Rs. 8,500 this router also has a USB port and is built pretty well, though not as good as the Linksys routers.

My heart was very tempted to throw caution to the wind and over-spend on the WRT610N. After all, even if I never used the dual-bands or the storage link feature, I'd have a flagship router. However, common sense prevailed and I settled for the WRT120N – I managed to get the guy down to 2,500 bucks. Upon reaching home, I opened her up and set things up. I heaved a sigh of relief as I found that even this, basically an entry-level N router was able to provide very good connectivity and signal integrity. I hooked up my cellphone, iPod Touch and my notebook and was relieved to see all three devices surfing pretty snappily. Being myself, I immediately upgraded my routers firmware to the latest version available and updated all drivers and software. Now I can proudly say my house is Wi-Fied; and I get to enjoy surfing from just about anywhere within it!

